PRESS INFORMATION BUREAU
GOVERNMENT OF INDIA

PRIME MINISTER'S SPEECH AT RED FORT

New Delhi, Sravana 24, 1891
August 15, 1969

Following is the free translation of the speech delivered in Hindi by the Prime Minister, Shrimati Indira Gandhi, from the ramparts of Red Fort today on the occasion of the 22nd anniversary of India's Independence:

"We have once more assembled at this historic place. This day is a mile-stone in our history and gives an opportunity to look back on our achievements and on our failures. At the same time it gives an opportunity to look ahead and to see which way we have to go and to which way we are going.

I wish you the best of luck on this day. This is the day when we look towards our great leaders, to our martyrs who laid down their life and sacrificed their happiness and all at the alter of the country. We call Mahatma Gandhi as the Father of the Nation. The very mention of the word Red Fort reminds us of Netaji Subash Chander Bose and each and every corner of the country is studded with the foot prints and memories of Jawaharlal Nehru.

The Jalianwala Bagh massacre took place fifty years ago when men, women, children - young and old - fell victims to the bullets in very large numbers. That was a turning point in the freedom struggle of our country. We have observed the 50th anniversary of this tragedy this year. After that on the

bank of the Ravi we had pledged ourselves to complete Independence and then in Karachi, in Lucknow, in Avadi and in Bhuvneshwar. We resolve to march forward with determined steps to implement our policies and programmes and we marched forward in the right direction.

We all know what has happened in the country during these years; what has happened in our countryside, in the field of agriculture and the general progress we have made over the years. Production of foodgrains has increased, the abolition of Zamindari we have tried to relieve the distress of our most oppressed and suppressed peasants, but we know that, in spite of all efforts, there are some failings too. Not only has there been tremendous progress in the field of industry but, really speaking, all the important industries have been set up only after the attainment of Independence. Even in this field our efforts have been to establish big industries only in the public sect and to abolish monopoly, but we know that we have been successful only to a limited extent and all that we h has not been realised. Big industries have been es in the public sector and they are still being set voices have been raised in their criticism but appraisal is made then we find that these enterpris doing very well. Our peasants are well aware that how greatly they have been benefited by these projects.

Their needs of water, electricity and of many other things have been met. We also know that there are few industries which are not running as satisfactorily as

should but we are doing our best to improve their conditions because not only that these industries are not the property of the Government but they are the property of the people an the earlier they start yielding profits and the better they function, the more would be the profits flowing to the masses from them. Our country is forging ahead in every field. Of course, there have been crisis in the life of the country whether the spector of war on our frontiers o draught stalking our land or communal riots or other dis turbances - all these have done damage to the country but I also realise that all these calamities have added to our experience. We have learnt a lot from them and we have marched forward with more resolute steps. Today, I believe that India has emerged out of darkness and it is for the first time in the last three or four years that there is a light brightening the horizon and shedding new lustre on ou country. Whereas many areas, many dwellings and many cities are flooded with this light how can we afford to forget th households which are still engulfed in darkness, how can forget those peasants whose lands have no irrigation facil ties; how can we forget those crores of Harijans and Girij and those brothers and sisters of backward tribes who live in the mountains or in the jungles and whose houses are st denied this light of free India. We had given them h had assured them that after Independence they will new light and life but I am afraid that their h been fulfilled. We have to accomplish all t

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we can accomplish many things. Our society, the Government and the people - all of us - have to unite together and help these down-trodden people and to assure them a new life. We are forging ahead but as I told you many a time violence breaks out and sometimes some things are done against the minorities which create suspicions and arouse anger against them. It also disturbs our unity which, in turn, disturbs the peace in the country. We all know that if peace is disturbed our production cannot increase. Every section of the people has some problems and difficulties and as we go ahead some new difficulties crop up and we have to face them. For this we want all our strength and this strength can be conserved and utilised only when we solve each other's problems and difficulties unitedly.

When banks were nationalized some rumours were set afloat that this step was directed against a particular section of our society. I want to make it perfectly clear that we do not propose to do anything against anybody. We want that all of us should march forward together. But I want to convince the rich and the capitalists that the step that we have taken is not directed against them. But it is only in the interest of the people: and a measure, which is in the interest of the masses, is in their interest also. They should look at this step and all that happened in the country from this point of view.

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us. But I can also see that we have gone ahead in the right direction. Just now, I mentioned a few cities and indicated their association with our resolutions that we had adopted for our journey towards socialism. This path of socialism has been chosen by the people of India through the democratic processes and it continues to have their approval. One very significant step in that direction has just now been taken. You all know what it is - the nationalization of banks. I am fully conscious of the tremendous spontaneous reception it has received from the people. A large number of people - big and small - who came to meet me or who wrote to me or who daily send messages to me to tell me that this is a right step in the right direction. And again, the picture of the new India has conjured up before my vision and I feel that still there are many people left for whom we have to do a lot of work. Rickshawalas, tongawalas, stone-breakers - all these people came to me. These are the people who are undergoing the worst hardships in the cities of free India. But we have to enable these people to share this new light and infuse in them new hopes for a better and richer life. Not that they would be greatly helped but by showing them a new path, perhaps, we can materially improve the conditions of their life and it is just possible that they may try to change their professions because the world is changing. Many old things are gradually changing, whether we like them or not. We have also to solve the unemployment problem and have to help everybody and provide equal opportunities to all. This,

When Mahatma Gandhi started the freedom movement a great revolution took place in our country. But he brought about this revolution with great humility and with the co-operation of all. Nobody could realise that he brought about such a great revolution in the country which changed the face of the country. He emancipated the country from the clutches of a foreign power. The revolution that took place has not ended yet because in a fast changing world, our country and society has to keep changing constantly.

I am pained to learn that some voices have been raised against the step that we have taken and have laid a charge that bank nationalization was done at the instance of some foreign power. But I want to make it unequvocally clear that whatever steps we are taking, we are doing so at the dictates of the masses and in the interest of our democracy. I know that the spirit of democracy is well entrenched in the hearts of the Indian people. I am also sure that they would never do anything which may result in any harm to our country and which may compromise our independence.

Our army, which is here today, which is also posted at the far-flung posts of our frontiers and which is standing guard on our mountains and jungles, in winter and summer and in rainy season, is our real protector. This army is not only the saviour of the whole country, of our people, rich and poor, big and small, but it is the defender of our independence, our political independence, of the freedom of our ideas, our cultural freedom; all these things are safe.

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in their hands. The path we have dchosen is the right path. That is the path born out of our history and culture. This is also true that every step that we take becomes a new step in course of time. What is the reason that in spite of so much of progress that we have made minds of some people are still disturbed and they are dissatisfied. I think there has been some failing. Man wants something more than progress and development and there comes a time in man's life when a revolution emerges from his heart, from the inner-most recess of his being and when he can recognise his soul more deeply and can view his surroundings more clearly. Such a time has come in the life of India today and a new era has ushered in. Those accustomed to living in closed atmosphere are worried by the blowing of this cool and fresh breeze; but there are also some people who are fed up with the suffocation and therefore would get new strength and new life by the contact of this new breeze.

Twenty-two years ago India awoke in freedom from a night of darkness. Panditji had declared on that memorable occasion that we had set off to have tryst with our destiny. Again, we have reached a similar turning point because our future is limitless and is unfolded vastly before us. Tomorrow's future is today's present. The way is vast open before us. As we progress forward we have to see that we adopt new path so that our country may go ahead rapidly.

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This is the Gandhi Centenary year. We have not only to keep the programmes of Gandhiji fresh in our memory but we have also to remember the basic ideals and principles of Gandhiji and we have to familiarise our new generation with them so that they may know and feel that such a great man was ever born in our country and who actually laid down the foundation of New India.

Another great man is to visit our country in the near future. All of you must have heard the name of Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan. He was the greatest disciple of Gandhiji. I have every hope that when he visits India we will welcome him with an open heart. Our people called him 'Frontier Gandhi' and showered upon him our deepest respect and affection.

This is an age of science and an age of youth. They have to follow this new path and they have not to look towards anybody else because those who look towards others for guidance are left behind in the present day world. We have to show a new path to our youngmen. I know our youngmen are endowed with new courage and determination. Situated as we are, old experiences are not enough. It is by cultivating courage, hope, self-reliance and self-confidence that we can make progress not only individually but collectively and we can carry our masses forward.

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We have saluted this tri-colour. This is a symbol of our democracy, of the unity and peace of our country, of our development and progress. Therefore, we have to cultivate all these qualities in ourselves. It is our duty to preserve the honour of this wheel of peace which has been given to us by Emperor Ashoka.

Standing before you I can assure you that wherever I am and whatever work I am doing the paramount thing before me is that I would always be working in your interest, in the interest of the masses. In this connection I want to give you the talisman which Gandhiji had given us. He had said that if you are assailed by doubts while taking a step you should always think of the lowest and the weakest. If that step is going to improve the lot of the poorest and the weakest then that step is right and proper and then if you march forward on the path all your doubts will be removed and the way will be cleared. In this spirit I want to go ahead. As I told you all of us have made great progress but we got struck up in some small and big programmes which were intended to improve the lot of the common man. But we actually forgot the common man. In the present day world wherever we go we find brave slogans and people think that these slogans are an end in themselves. It is, however, seldom realized to what extent they promote the interest of the poor and the needy.

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Today we have taken a new turn. A new dawn has set in. I believe that if our youth, the peasants, the labourers, whether they are in the army or in cities or in rural areas, follow this new path they will bring about a wave of new enthusiasm and produce a new spirit of sacrifice. Today we have only to think of the masses, of the poor people of the country. If we can raise them we can raise ourselves. If we have strength and along with it compassion in our hearts, then we can raalise the difficulties of others and we can sympathise with others and then alone can we accomplish big tasks unitedly. I have every reason to believe that the people of India would always stand together unitedly.

I wish you all the best of luck today. We have taken steps towards a new development, new vistas has been opened and a cool and fresh breeze is blowing about our faces. I will only say this to you that you need not be afraid of this fresh breeze; but we should march forward with courage and if we can march forward with determination we can certainly achieve something beyond. Whether we turn it to our advantage or disadvantage is entirely in our own hands.

We have been a peaceful nation. At the same time we are aware that peace does not mean weakness. By peace is meant our determination to stand on our legs firmly to

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achieve self-reliance and to prepare for our defence. Peac is not derived from weakness but is achieved by strength, by self-reliance, by self-confidence. I want that every Indian should cultivate these qualities. Mahatma Gandhi had produced freedom fighters out of the poor and defenceles people and turned them into a strong army of determined people. We can also further strengthen that spirit because our people today are more knowledgeable, more competent and more determined to go ahead.

Let us now raise the slogan of the unity and strength of the country. Many children are sitting in front of me. They are the citizens of tomorrow and we have great hopes from them. We want them to have equal opportunities. We have to reduce the disparity between high and l low, between the rich and the poor as well as between one section and another section of the society. We have also t reduce the gap between what we are and what we want to bec Now let us raise the national slogan together "Jai Hind".

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